Stuck in Neutral

By Terry Trueman

SHAWN'S INNER VOICE: My name is Shawn McDaniel. My life is like one of those "good news—bad news" jokes. Like, "I've got some good news and some bad news– which do you wanna hear first?" In the jokes, it's always the good news first, so here goes: my mom and dad love me!

I could go on about my good news for hours, but you probably want to hear the punch line, my bad news, right? This bad news is complicated, difficult to explain. In a nutshell, it's that I am pretty sure that my dad is planning to kill me. The good news is that he'd be doing this out of his love for me. The bad news is that whatever the wonderfulness of his motives, I'll be dead.

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INTRODUCTION

Shawn McDaniel is an enigma and a miracle--except no one knows it, least of all his father. His life is not what it may seem to anyone looking at him. Not even those who love him best have any idea what he is truly like. Today, I personally challenge you to look beyond the obvious and truly see a person whose spirit is rich beyond imagining and whose story is unforgettable.

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SHAWN'S INNER VOICE: Every year the school district sends out a school psychologist (scientist) to test me -- mainly intelligence tests filled with questions like "Who was George Washington?" and "What's two plus one?" And every year I sit there and miss every question. Then the shrink goes in and gives my mom a number: I.Q. = 1.2, or mental age 3 to 4 (that's months, not years).

(Transition into the vocal qualities and mannerisms of someone with CP)

SHAWN'S VOICE IMPACTED BY CP: The deal is, I have cerebral palsy. I can't control any of my muscles: not my fingers, my eyes, [my voice] . . . none of them. Not a one. So when the psychologist says, "Who was George Washington?" I can't tell him what I know. All I can do is

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sit there and drool if my drool function is running, or go, "ahhhhhh!"

(Transition back to regular mannerisms and speech)

SHAWN'S INNER VOICE: When people first meet me, they usually speak real slowly and real loudly:

ALLY: Hi Shawn, nice to meet you! My name is Ally Williamson! How are you!

(Transition into the vocal qualities and mannerisms of someone with CP)

SHAWN'S VOICE IMPACTED BY CP: Well, I'm not deaf! *(Beat)* Oh, but it gets worse. You should see my mom!

MOM: Goo-goo-baby boy-go . . . you a big baby boy . . . boogie woogie googie snoogie.

SHAWN'S VOICE IMPACTED BY CP: It's OK, you can laugh. I do! You know, people mean well. They just don't always know how to show it. Like my dad.

(Transition back to regular mannerisms and speech)

SHAWN'S INNER VOICE: I guess I should explain about my father, about why I think he's planning to kill me. It's not as though he's stated it directly. It's more an intuition -- intuition and a thing that happened last week when my dad stopped by the house.

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DAD: How're you doing, big boy? Everything going okay for you? Any hot news for me? *(Laughs)*

SHAWN'S INNER VOICE: He laughed at his joke, not a big or happy or mean laugh, but a quiet, sad one. Then he leaned over in front of me and brought his face down close to mine. With his brown eyes only inches away from my eyes, it felt as though he were trying to stare through me, straight through my eyes and into my brain.

DAD: *(softly)* You're not getting any of this, are you, Shawn?

(Transition into the vocal qualities and mannerisms of someone with CP)

SHAWN'S VOICE IMPACTED BY CP: In fourteen years I've heard him say my name aloud in my presence a total of sixteen times.

DAD: God . . . look what he did to you! You can't even protect yourself, Shawn. I can't protect you, or your mom or anyone else. You know I love you, right? When I think about you, Shawn, my heart breaks. When I think about you hurting, I can barely even breathe, my chest aches so badly. I want to help you, Shawn, I do.

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But I just don't know how. Am I supposed to let all your pain and your seizures continue, or should I just end it. Is that what you want, Shawn – you want me to end your pain?

SHAWN'S INNER VOICE: No, I don't want that! End my pain? It made me mad. What right does he have to decide what's best for me? What right does he have to think about ending my pain? . . . You see, I know he loves me, but when he looks at me all he sees . . .

(Transition into the vocal qualities and mannerisms of someone with CP)

SHAWN'S VOICE IMPACTED BY CP: . . . is this twisted, drooling pile of flesh. *(Beat)* What do you see? You know, it's just a shock to me. There's an actual person inside here who wants to be seen and loved, but of course, I can't tell him. He can't hear me. You see, he can only remember what happened.

(Transition back to regular mannerisms and speech)

SHAWN'S INNER VOICE: One day I was out on our front porch sitting in my wheelchair, when this guy showed up . . .

GUY: Hey! You know if the bus has come by or not? Hey!

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You there, Roller Derby, has the bus come by or not?

(Transition into the vocal qualities and mannerisms of someone with CP)

SHAWN'S VOICE IMPACTED BY CP: Ahhhhhh!

GUY: Are you laughing at me, huh? Did I say something funny. Look at me when I'm talking to you. Did I say something funny? Maybe I should teach you some respect, huh?

SHAWN'S VOICE IMPACTED BY CP: Then he held a lighter under my chin.

GUY: Not's so funny now, huh?

SHAWN'S VOICE IMPACTED BY CP: Ahhhhhh!

(Transition back to regular mannerisms and speech)

SHAWN'S INNER VOICE: Do you know what it's like to smell your own flesh burning and not be able to do anything about it? He burned a hole under my chin and I couldn't even stop him. When my dad came out, he freaked. Without a word the stranger scurried out our open gate. In ten seconds he was gone. We never saw him again.

(Transition into the vocal qualities and mannerisms of someone with CP)

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SHAWN'S VOICE IMPACTED BY CP: So now I have to worry about what my dad is going to do to me. Is my father going to kill me? When? How? What's going to happen?

DAD: When you were born, and we were told that you'd have these kinds of problems, I got down on my knees and prayed harder than I'd ever prayed, begging God or Satan, or anybody in between, to let me trade places with you. I prayed, night after night, that I could be the one trapped inside your body and that you could take my place. I don't know what to do, son. Shawn . . . I love you.

(Transition back to regular mannerisms and speech)

SHAWN'S INNER VOICE: You know, I just wish for one moment that I could have complete control over my body. Just for 2 minutes. So I could tell my dad that I love him and I could cuddle with my mom. So I could tell her that I love her and tell my dad that I AM happy and that his unconditional love . . .

(Transition into the vocal qualities and mannerisms of someone with CP)

SHAWN'S VOICE IMPACTED BY CP: . . . is everything I need. And that I'm just sorta stuck in neutral.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier – MS
IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

Find out more about Cerebral Palsy here:
https://www.cdc.gov/ncbddd/cp/facts.html

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